A WISE COUNSEL

Pallavi Shroff, *67*
Lawyer, Managing Partner, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co

IT WAS HER SECOND WEEK OF legal practice and she was arguing in the court of Justice Leila Seth, when her husband Shardul Shroff, scion of the legendary Amarchand & Mangaldas & Suresh A Shroff & Co, sought to help her with her arguments. Justice Seth stopped him, saying Pallavi was perfectly capable of arguing on her own.

When you are the daughter of P.N. Bhagwati, the former Chief Justice of India, and married into an equally illustrious family, stepping out of giant shadows may seem daunting. Perhaps why Pallavi started out "selling detergent in the market", after an MBA from the Jamnalal Bajaj Institute. She took up law in 1980 only to be in the same profession as her husband so that she could spend more time with him. "Besides, my business background would be an added advantage for a firm that was into corporate litigation," says Pallavi.

Four decades on, the managing partner of Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas is the doyenne of corporate litigation in the country. She has successfully represented Indian and global companies in top courts in India and abroad. For her expertise in dispute resolution, competition laws and white-collar crimes, the Union government nominated her as a member of the Competition Law Review Committee, which submitted its report in July 2019. Now, she is a member of the Committee on Digital Competition Law to examine the need for a separate law on competition in digital markets.

For someone who was given the freedom to choose a career of her choice by her father and treated as a third son by her in-laws, things weren't easy for Pallavi. "When I started," she recounts, "women were not taken seriously as lawyers. Judges would often ask if I was waiting for my husband or other seniors to join me." Her answer? Let hard work do the talking. She never missed a court appearance, even though her younger daughter would fall ill frequently. "I didn't want anyone to think I was available only when family issues let me."

And having faced it herself, Pallavi wants to make sure younger women are spared such inherent and unconscious bias. In her own firm, she has been behind several initiatives for women, including flexi work arrangements and hours, daycares and special training programmes. Far too many times, she had had to celebrate her daughter's birthday in office or have her children sit in the last benches of courtrooms while she argued. Now, she wants to leave behind an institution that will grow after she and Shardul have moved on. ■

–Kaushik Deka



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Is member of the Committee on Digital Competition Law

FIGHTING STEREOTYPES

"When I started, women were not taken seriously as lawyers. Judges would ridicule the fact that I used to carry books to courts"

HER OTHER PASSION Kathak. Has trained with Kumudini Lakhia and Birju Maharaj